SPORTS OF THE TIMES

Andy Cohen Recalls Past Glories as Giant Infielder

BY ARTHUR DALEY

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CLEARWATER, Fla. March 28 — When Andy Cohen joined the Giants in 1926, he merely had to beat out Frank Frisch for the job at second base. No one was beating Frisch for anything in those days. A year later the Fordham Flash had been traded for Rogers Hornsby and the Rajah took over the job at second. No one could beat out Hornsby, either.

But in 1928 both Hall of Famers had departed and Andy Cohen was the Giant second baseman. In no time at all he was the darling of the East Side, the Bronx, Bensonhurst and way stations. So sensational was his hitting that a tabloid began printing a daily box, comparing Cohen's average of .400-plus with Hornsby's .250-minus. After a couple of weeks the blunt-spoken Rajah came to town with the Braves.

Dirty Trick

"It's a dirty trick that they're playing on that kid," snapped the finest right-hand batsman that baseball ever produced. "As soon as I get going, I'll leave that boy so far behind that they'll never find him."

Andy Cohen laughed delightedly as he recounted that story. The soft-spoken Texan from El Paso is back in the big leagues again after an absence of 31 years. He's as happy and as shiny-eyed in his job as coach of the Phils as he was in 1926 when he joined the Giants after the skimpy apprenticeship of a half season in the Texas League and three years at the University of Alabama.

Batted .274

"For a rookie I didn't do bad," he said. "I hit a respectable .274. But Hornsby hit .387 to win another batting championship. Naturally, I wasn't in his class. But nobody else was, either.

"I got an awful lot of publicity that year. They said I was the Jewish ball player John McGraw always wanted. But McGraw was primarily interested in good ball players although I know he felt that a Jewish one wouldn't do any harm at the gate.

"In a way, I had two debuts, two games that stand out in my mind above all others. The first was my first at bat as a big leaguer. It was in 1926 and, oddly enough, I went in as a pinch hitter for Frisch. Whoa! don't jump at conclusions. Frank had a bad foot, the game was won and Mac sent him to the clubhouse early. Mac gave me the gimlet eye and told me to bat for Frisch.

Ripped Off Coat

"I was wearing a mackinaw and was so excited I couldn't unbutton it. So I ripped off the buttons. 'No regard for expense, eh?' said McGraw. And, of all the things, I got a hit. McGraw was smiling when I got back to the bench. 'Congratulations, young man,' he said. 'You are now leading the league in hitting.'

"A great man was McGraw. The next year he had Hornsby and he asked me if I wanted to sit on the bench or go to the minors. I took the minors. 'That's what I wanted to hear you say,' he said. So I went to Buffalo, hit .354 and came back to the Giants the next season as a regular.

"My second debut was opening day of 1928. I had three hits and either drove in or scored all four funs. The fans poured out of the stands and carried me on their shoulders all the way to the clubhouse steps. I also remember meeting Jimmy Walker and Jack Dempsey, a couple of heroes to a country boy from Texas."

Those were glorious days for Andy and his buddy on the Giants was a huge Boston Irishman named Shanty Hogan.

"He could have been one of the best catchers ever," said Andy sadly. "But he ate himself out of the big leagues. One year he came to camp weighing 265. He'd run all day in a rubber suit, practically sit on the stove in the clubhouse and take a hot shower to steam off more weight. But then he'd have to eat to regain his strength.

"I visited him often at his house. His mother would pass the chicken but there always was one whole chicken for Shanty. She'd pass the potatoes but there was one special big bowl for Shanty. She'd cut the pie for dessert but he'd have a whole pie by himself. McGraw tried to hold him down by watching his meal checks. But Shanty had private arrangements with the waitresses. He'd write down spinach but that meant potatoes. He had a whole code of his own.

"After the 1929 season, McGraw traded me off to Newark and I went great. I was hitting .318 and set an International League record of 59 consecutive games without an error. So Mac came over to see me. 'Andy,' he said, 'I'm bringing you back.' That day I broke my leg.

"So I've had a long wait to get back, more than 30 years. It's worth waiting for, too, because there's nothing in life quite like the big leagues."

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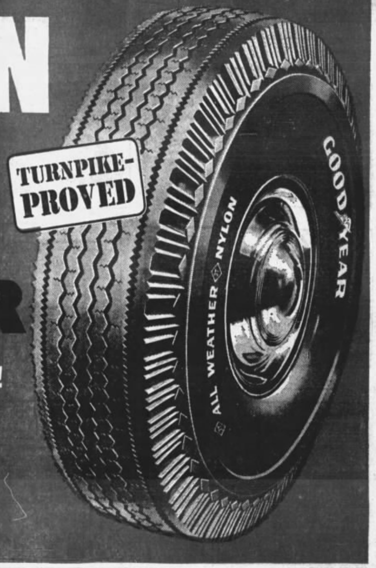

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